CSIS | KOREA DAILY BRIEF

Saturday, November 14, 2026 No. 234 9 min read

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. US experts at a CSIS event assessed Trump views wartime OPCON transfer as a vehicle to withdraw US forces from Korea.
2. China's Wang Yi gave Seoul its most detailed account yet of Kim Jong Un's October 24 Dandong visit during FM-level talks.
3. People Power Party held a Busan street rally against the National Assembly-passed 'fabricated prosecution special counsel bill.'

KOSPI	USD/KRW	BRENT	LEE APPROVAL	KIM LAST SEEN	BOK RATE
5,290.53	1,336.20	$95.84	41%	Today	3.00%
−1.0%	+0.2%	+0.0%	+2 pts Nov 3-5	public appearance	Oct 2026

01 | TOP STORIES

Yonhap, US-Korea

Trump seen using OPCON transfer as path to US troop withdrawal, experts warn

Yonhap / Korea Times, China-Korea

China gives Seoul detailed account of Kim's Dandong visit; calls ties 'economic, not political'

Wang Yi elaborated on Kim Jong Un's October 24 visit to Dandong during talks with **FM Cho Hyun** in Beijing on November 13, with a South Korean official saying China described its North Korea relationship as focused on economic cooperation rather than political affairs.

The official assessed a US-North Korea summit as possible but not highly likely, saying it would depend on US President Donald Trump's willingness. Cho called on China to play a constructive role in bringing North Korea back to dialogue.

02 | OVERNIGHT

Reuters, China-Korea

FM Cho: South Korea should not fear China's rise

Said after Beijing FM talks.

The Korea Times, NK-Russia-China

Beijing says its North Korea ties focus on economics, not politics, Seoul official

Chinese characterization after Cho-Wang Yi talks.

NK News, NK-Russia-China

Russia and North Korea to run 14 daily bus round trips over new Tumangang bridge

Experts say workers, not tourists, the likely passengers.

Daily NK, NK-Russia-China

Six North Korean workers killed in Russia Far East train crash in October

No regime accountability mechanism identified.

Korea Times, Technology

ICT ministry to inspect domestic disruptions after Microsoft services outage

Ministry forming joint emergency team with Microsoft Korea.

Chosun Ilbo, ROK Politics

South Korea ends 21-year unbeaten streak with 3-2 loss to Saudi Arabia

First loss to Saudi Arabia since 2005.

Hankook Ilbo, NK-Russia-China

US media reports Trump-Xi-Putin trilateral at Shenzhen APEC on November 19; North Korea on possible agenda

No official schedule confirmed; nuclear arms control cited as primary US goal.

03 | STAT OF THE DAY

$1.2B

Binance funds DOJ moved to seize in North Korean crypto case

The US Department of Justice moved to freeze nearly half of more than $6 billion stolen in North Korea's Binance hack, the largest single crypto-seizure action targeting Pyongyang.

WSJ, Nov 14

04 | PYONGYANG WATCH

Kim Jong Un

Public appearance: Kim Jong Un inspected a second major east-coast naval base under construction on November 12-13, ordering that it be completed on the schedule and to the quality standard set by the party central.

No KCNA watch flag. 5 provocations logged in the last 7 days.

> *"Modern naval base construction is a major core project directly linked to our state's safety and defense of maritime sovereignty, and must unconditionally be completed within the period decided by the party central and at the quality level demanded by the party central."*
>
> **Kim Jong Un**, N. Korea's Kim inspects east coast naval base under construction, urges timely completion

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

NK News

North Korea faked November 4 cluster warhead test using doctored photos from 2022

NK News reports that North Korea's November 4 announced cluster warhead test was fabricated using doctored imagery from 2022, adding to a pattern of domestic weapons-test blackouts.

> **Bottom line:** State media led with Kim's second consecutive east-coast naval base inspection; NK News separately reported the November 4 cluster warhead test was fabricated using 2022 imagery.

05 ROK GOVERNMENT

President and ministries, Saturday, November 14, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

FM Cho Hyun

Cho meets Wang Yi in Beijing; urges China to bring North Korea back to dialogue

FM Cho Hyun met Chinese FM Wang Yi in Beijing on November 13 for approximately three hours of talks and dinner, the first ministerial meeting in about three months. Cho stressed that peninsula peace serves shared interests and called on China to play a constructive role; Wang reaffirmed Beijing's unchanged Korea Peninsula policy and welcomed President Lee's planned APEC attendance in Shenzhen.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**
Reported **Korea Times**

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Climate Ambassador Kang Geum-sil

Korea signs climate cooperation framework agreement with Nepal at COP31

Korea has pursued the agreement with Nepal since 2024.

Primary **Foreign Ministry**

MINISTRY OF TRADE, INDUSTRY AND ENERGY

Minister Kim Jeong-gwan

Industry minister assures Czech counterpart Czech nuclear project on schedule; regular ministerial consultations to begin

Industry Minister Kim Jeong-gwan told his Czech counterpart that the Czech nuclear plant project will proceed on schedule without disruption and agreed to activate a regular ministerial-level consultative body, with a first session before year-end.

Asia Economy

PERSONNEL CHANGES

William Daley APPOINTED
CSIS Board of Trustees Chair
William Daley was named Chair of the CSIS Board of Trustees. Paul Ryan was named Vice Chair.

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

National Assembly passes 'fabricated prosecution special counsel bill'

Full plenary / National Assembly

The ruling Democratic Party drove passage of the so-called 'fabricated prosecution special counsel bill' through the National Assembly plenary on November 14, triggering a major PPP rally in Busan. PPP leader Jang Dong-hyuk called the bill 100 percent unconstitutional and demanded a presidential veto.

06 US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

TARIFF STATUS

Autos and parts Section 232	**15%** Reduced
Steel and aluminum Section 232	**50%** Active
Reciprocal tariff 10% surcharge (Section 122), expired Jul 24 2026	**Expired**
Section 301 USTR, Section 301 determination, pending, no fixed date	**Active**

6 more sector rates on the trade reference page; no rate changed since the last issue.

Steel and aluminum remain at 50% and automobiles at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff in force. Section 301 investigations, launched March 11 against 16 trading partners including South Korea, are now the primary prospective tariff vehicle.

INVESTMENT PLEDGE, $350B

$350B pledged; 1 project selected so far, led by Encinal gas-fired power plant, Texas ($22.3B).

$150B shipbuilding (MASGA), $200B strategic sectors, $100B US energy purchases; no official drawdown figure reported to date.

07 CAPITOL HILL

Korea JoongAng Daily, House, Legislation

US House passes small business protection bill targeting North Korean and other foreign threats

The US House passed a bill to shield small businesses from foreign threats including North Korea, according to VOA Korean service. The measure addresses cybersecurity and economic security vulnerabilities at the small-business level.

The Korea Times, Legislation

China's access to Nvidia chips in doubt as export curbs gain traction in US Congress

Congressional momentum for tighter Nvidia chip export controls to China is growing following the Jensen Huang scandal, with bipartisan interest in restricting advanced AI chip flows. The Korea Times notes Korean chipmakers Samsung and SK Hynix could face secondary effects on their China fab operations.

08 NORTHEAST ASIA WATCH

Korea Times, China-Korea

Cho-Wang Yi talks: Seoul requests constructive Chinese role on North Korea; FTA services talks to advance

Cho also raised the West Sea (Yellow Sea) issue and protection of Korean nationals in China.

upi, China-Korea

South Korea seeks EU exemptions for steel, nuclear equipment

Seoul is pursuing European Union exemptions for Korean steel exports and nuclear equipment, UPI reports, as part of broader efforts to diversify trade policy relief following US Section 232 tariff pressure.

upi, Japan-Korea

South Korea holds separate Sado mine memorial, pressing Japan on historical record

South Korea held a separate memorial ceremony for Korean victims of the Sado mine, maintaining pressure on Japan to fully acknowledge the history of wartime forced labor at the UNESCO World Heritage site.

09 KOREA AND THE WORLD

The Korea News Plus, Europe, Nuclear & energy

KHNP reviews Czech nuclear project progress with local client

Korea Hydro and Nuclear Power (KHNP) reviewed progress on the Czech nuclear project with its local client, as Industry Minister Kim Jeong-gwan separately assured his Czech counterpart the project would proceed on schedule with a regular ministerial-level consultative channel activated before year-end.

Korea Herald (via UA.NEWS), South Asia, Trade

Kia plans to invest $2 billion in second plant in India

Kia plans to invest $2 billion in a second manufacturing plant in India, Korea Herald reports, deepening the South Korean automaker's presence in one of the world's fastest-growing auto markets.

The Edge Malaysia, Southeast Asia, Defense exports

Malaysia to receive all 18 FA-50M fighter jets from South Korea by March 2028

Malaysia's defense minister confirmed all 18 FA-50M light combat aircraft ordered from South Korea will be delivered by March 2028. The FA-50M contract is part of Seoul's growing defense export portfolio in Southeast Asia.

10 BUSINESS & ECONOMY

Hankook Ilbo

US Treasury Secretary blames Commerce for failure to sanction Nvidia chip-diversion suspect Megaspeed

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent publicly blamed Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick's department for not blacklisting Singaporean firm Megaspeed, suspected of diverting Nvidia chips to China, saying Treasury, State, Defense and USTR all agreed months ago to add it. Bessent said Trump had been clear China must not receive Nvidia chips beyond the A100 level, and that the authority to enforce already exists.

Nvidia

Dong-A Ilbo

South Korea lays groundwork for homegrown Starlink satellite constellation

South Korea is developing the foundational infrastructure for a domestic satellite internet constellation analogous to Starlink, Dong-a Ilbo reports. The initiative reflects Seoul's push for strategic communications autonomy.

11 UPCOMING

NOV 17

Hudson Institute event: Overcoming US-ROK Alliance Challenges

Hudson Institute hosts a panel titled 'Overcoming US-ROK Alliance Challenges: Trade, Technology, and China' on November 17.

12 ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun (@FMChoHyun), November 13

"Met again with Chinese FM Wang Yi in Beijing three months after our August meeting in Korea, discussing Korea-China relations and Korean Peninsula issues over talks and dinner. We discussed creating concrete outcomes in Korea-China relations that our citizens can feel. President Lee will attend the Shenzhen APEC summit in a few days; I will work until the last moment to make this visit an important occasion for developing Korea-China relations."

The post confirms the November 13 ministerial as Beijing's pre-APEC diplomatic preparation ahead of a planned Lee-Xi bilateral on the summit sidelines. **View on X**

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.

COMMENTARY

William Daley and Paul Ryan Named Chair and Vice Chair of the CSIS Board of Trustees. CSIS announced the appointment of William Daley as Chair and Paul Ryan as Vice Chair of its Board of Trustees. The leadership change affects the institution that houses the Korea Chair and several other flagship programs. No Korea-specific programmatic changes were announced alongside the leadership transition. (CSIS, CSIS)

China and Russia's Role in North Korea's Human Rights Abuses | The Capital Cable #79. The piece examines the roles China and Russia play in North Korea's human rights abuses. (CSIS Center for Strategic and International Studies)

13 PUBLIC SENTIMENT

Lee approval

41%

+2 pts vs Oct 27-29
Gallup Korea
November 3-5, 2026

Trend: Down from 42% on Aug 25-27, across 8 readings.

Ruling	Opposition	Independents
Democratic	People Power	
36%	**28%**	**28%**

Gallup Korea publishes weekly; this reading is 1 week old (November 3-5, 2026).

14 THE WIRE

DPRK

WSJ

Kim Jong Un remakes North Korea's flag, ditching Soviet-era design

WSJ reports Kim Jong Un has formally modified North Korea's national flag, breaking from the Soviet-era design embedded in the revised constitution published earlier this month. The flag change was formalized alongside broader constitutional revisions that expanded Kim's powers and codified the two-state framework.

WSJ

DOJ freezes nearly half of $6B stolen in North Korea's Binance hack

The US Department of Justice said it helped freeze nearly half of more than $6 billion stolen in North Korea's Binance hack, moving to seize $1.2 billion in funds. The action follows an FBI report that North Korean hackers stole more than $400 million in cryptocurrency over the last 18 months.

NK News

Kim Jong Un inspects second major east-coast naval base, orders timely completion

Kim Jong Un inspected a second major east-coast naval base under construction on November 12-13, ordering completion on the schedule and to the quality standard set by the party central. NK News separately identified the second base project beyond the Munchon-area site Kim first visited on November 12.

US-KOREA

The Korea Herald

US nationwide flight halt delays Incheon departures to New York, Atlanta, Boston

A US Federal Aviation Administration nationwide ground stop caused by air traffic control communications problems delayed Incheon flights to New York, Atlanta and Boston by approximately two hours Saturday. The FAA said the outage affected 22 regional air traffic control centers; US Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin indicated no evidence of malicious activity.

ROK ECONOMY

Dong-A Ilbo

Iran warns South Korea over expanded naval mission

Iran issued a warning to South Korea over an expanded ROK naval mission, according to Dong-a Ilbo. The warning comes as Seoul has maintained a naval presence in waters relevant to Mideast security operations.

ROK POLITICS

Carnegie Endowment for International Peace

What's Behind South Korea's Rift With Ukraine and Turn Toward Russia?

Carnegie Politika traces Seoul's diplomatic rupture with Kyiv to the September 23 UN General Assembly dispute over North Korean prisoners of war, culminating in Seoul recalling its ambassador from Ukraine on October 8. The piece notes signs of South Korean reengagement with Russia but identifies limits to how far the foreign-policy shift will go.

15 | SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

Elevated or alert, 2 of 11 sites: Yongbyon Nuclear Complex; Sohae Satellite Launch Station.

No new reporting on any of the 11 monitored sites since the last issue.

That's today's brief. No. 234

Feedback and tips are welcome. Write to **alim@csis.org**.

CSIS | GEOPOLITICS AND FOREIGN POLICY DEPARTMENT | KOREA CHAIR

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